SDA lab: national survey data in one period

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TEACHER PAGE · ONE 45-MINUTE PERIOD

Students learn to find a variable in the General Social Survey, read its codebook entry, run one table, and save it. Nobody's question is rewritten. The lab only shows what public data exists.

Setup

- Go to `sda.berkeley.edu`, choose **Archive**, then **General Social Survey (GSS) Cumulative Datafile 1972-2024 - release 3 (SDA 4)**. No login.
- Test once on a student iPad before class. Results open in a new tab, so pop-ups must be allowed.

Run of the period

Minutes	What happens
0 to 5	Frame it: real researchers reuse data. Thousands of adults answered these questions, and the answers are free. Hand out the student sheet.
5 to 15	**Demo on the board.** Type `consci` in **Row** and `degree` in **Column**. Leave the weight as it is. Press **Run the Table**. Then open the **Codebook** tab and show the exact question for `consci`.
15 to 35	Students work through steps 1 to 5 on their sheet. Circulate. The common snag is a variable that was only asked in some years.
35 to 45	Students finish the record box and the two exit lines. Collect the sheets.

What the demo should show

Confidence in the scientific community, by highest degree. In the row "a great deal," the column percentages rise from **34.6** for less than high school to **60.5** for a graduate degree. Valid cases: **47,772**. Checked on November 11, 2026. A newer data release may shift these slightly.

Three things to say out loud

- **Read down, compare across.** Each column adds to 100. Compare the same row across columns.
- **A pattern is not a cause.** The table shows that two answers go together. It cannot show that one produces the other.
- **The question is the measurement.** Whatever the survey asked, in those exact words, is what the number means.

Useful moves

- Change over time: put `year` in **Column**.
- Recent years only: type `year(2018-2024)` in **Selection Filter(s)**.
- Save the table: open **Create and Download CSV File** before running. Charts are under **Chart Options**.

Rule for this lab: a student may discover that a dataset fits their question, or that it does not. The lab never suggests new wording for a question.

Find it, read it, run it, save it

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STUDENT SHEET · SDA LAB

STUDENT CODE _____ PERIOD _____ DATE _____

1. **Open the data.** `sda.berkeley.edu`, then Archive, then the General Social Survey 1972-2024, release 3.
2. **Search.** Use the **Search** tab. Try key words from your own question as it stands in your log. Do not change your question to fit a variable. If nothing fits, write "no match" below. That is a real finding.
3. **Read the codebook** for one variable. Find the exact question people were asked and the answer choices.
4. **Run one table.** Your variable goes in **Row**. Put a group to compare, such as `degree`, `sex`, or `year`, in **Column**. Press **Run the Table**.
5. **Save it.** Run it again with **Create and Download CSV File** open, or screenshot the table. This file is your data.

Record box: copy from the screen, exactly			
Dataset and release			
Variable name and label			
Exact question asked from the codebook			
Answer choices			
Years it was asked		**Column variable**	
Valid cases bottom of the results		**Weight shown**	

One thing this table shows (give the numbers)

One thing this table cannot show

If you use this in your paper: cite the General Social Survey (NORC at the University of Chicago, gss.norc.org) in the class citation style. Give the release from your record box, and say you analyzed it through SDA on today's date.